

Sports **IPL 2009**

peripheral expenses. Some teams will dispense with the brand ambassadors and others could even say goodbye to their cheerleaders (weep, boys).

Ticket sales should ideally generate Rs 20 crore all told, but some franchises could only earn between Rs 8 crore and Rs 10 crore last season on tickets. For the first time in Indian cricket, selling tickets—and the spectator experience—has become a priority.

In what should be a real reflection of the economic impact on the IPL, the League itself has to date tied with only three out of six associated sponsors, including one with Mallya's own Kingfisher. Chief Operating Officer of the Delhi Daredevils Amrit Mathur says that while times are tough, "Overall, there's faith in cricket. Cricket works in India and due to that, things will come around."

On the eve of Season 2, the lone bullish entity (other than Modi) seems to be Sony, "The IPL is the biggest property on TV," says Rohit Gupta, president, Sony Entertainment Television, "and it will have an uninterrupted run." Even in a recessionary year the IPL is six weeks of free entertainment for Middle India. Rekhi says, "There is no substitute for a three-hour, fast-paced unscripted drama." No channel will launch a *Paanchvi Paas* to try to grab rival eyeballs. There is no question of an Indian team imploding to sudden defeat and leaving the event without an audience. Gupta says 80 per cent of Season 1 sponsors are back. Rather than cut back on their television spends, corporates will, he says, "re-allocate budgets... but no one will want to be left out of the IPL".

Ad rates for the IPL spots are said to be as high as Rs 4 lakh for 10 seconds. Brands that cannot afford these rates can only hope that rates will dip to 2008 levels of Rs 80,000 per 10 seconds. Says Divya Radhakrishnan of TME India, Rediffusion DY&R, "For FMCG brands, which mostly target women, the IPL is not a cost-efficient property as it's too expensive and is mostly viewed by men.



PURUSHOTTAM DWIVAKAR

VIEWERS IN RURAL INDIA
ENJOY AN IPL GAME

SEASON 2 IS ANTICIPATED TO BE A TV HIT BECAUSE IT WILL MEAN SIX WEEKS OF FREE ENTERTAINMENT FOR INDIANS.



AFP

Rs 2.9 cr

was offered by KKR to get Bangladeshi **MASHRAFE MORTAZA** with the aim of expanding their fan base

So it's more cost-effective for FMCG brands to advertise in general entertainment channels."

The IPL may also squeeze the market of its overall cricket ad spend. Venu Nair, president (South Asia & UAE) of global media rights-holder WSG, says that all media budgets for the year will be made keeping the IPL and then the World T20 championship in mind. "Everyone is going to spend their money on the IPL—what will be affected is the cricket to follow."

In more ways than one. The IPL has changed the economics and the dynamics of cricket. In the future, it will put established notions about team loyalty, country and club under severe strain. For an entity so powerful, the IPL remains a tight club, remarkably under-scrutinised, its goings-on a shadow play in which image is everything. Hell, never mind the recession, what IPL seems closer to becoming is regulation-proof.

with Malini Bhupta